

the leaves also contain flavonoids and coumarins. The sesquiterpene lactones have a sedative effect.

History & Folklore In Assyrian herbal medicine, lettuce seeds were reportedly used with cumin (*Cuminum cyminum*, p. 197) as a poultice for the eyes. Dioscorides (1st century CE) wrote that the plant's effect resembled that of the opium poppy (*Papaver somniferum*, p. 244).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Wild lettuce is a safe sedative that can be given to adults and children to encourage a sound night's sleep or to calm overactivity or overstimulation. Most commonly, it is recommended for excitability in children. It is also taken to treat coughs, often in combination with herbs such as licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101). Wild lettuce is thought to lower the libido. It may also be used to relieve pain.

Research A 2011 Egyptian clinical trial found that lettuce seed oil improved sleep in people suffering from insomnia. Lettuce seed oil has traditionally been used in Egypt for sleep problems.

Related Species Garden lettuce (*L. sativa*) may be used like wild lettuce, but has a much weaker therapeutic action.

Lamium album (Lamiaceae) White Deadnettle

Description Perennial growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has a square stem, toothed oval leaves, and clusters of white double-lipped flowers.



White deadnettle is used to treat gynecological conditions.

Habitat & Cultivation White deadnettle is native to and widespread in Europe and central and northern Asia. It thrives in fields and in open areas. It is gathered when in flower in summer.

Parts Used Flowering tops.

Constituents White deadnettle contains a saponin, flavones, mucilage, and tannins.

History & Folklore Deadnettle is so called because it resembles true nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146), without the stinging hairs. It was also known as archangel, a plant "to make the heart merry, to make a good colour in the face, and to refresh the vital spirits" (John Gerard, *The Herball*, 1597).

Medicinal Actions & Uses White deadnettle is astringent and demulcent. It is chiefly used as a uterine tonic, to arrest intermenstrual bleeding, and to reduce excessive menstrual flow. It is also a traditional treatment for abnormal vaginal discharge. The herb is sometimes taken to relieve painful periods. Its astringency helps treat diarrhea, and, used externally, it can relieve hemorrhoids and varicose veins.

Larix decidua syn. *L. europaea* (Pinaceae)

Larch

Description Deciduous conifer growing to 165 ft (50 m). Has clusters of needle-like leaves, male and female flowers, and small, light brown cones.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Alps and the Carpathian mountains of eastern Europe, larch grows to altitudes of 6,600 ft (2,000 m). It is widely cultivated for its timber. The resin is tapped in autumn; the bark is collected when the tree is felled.

Parts Used Inner bark, resin.

Constituents Larch contains lignans, resins, and volatile oil (consisting mainly of alpha- and beta-pinene and limonene).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Larch has astringent, diuretic, and antiseptic properties. The bark may be used to treat bladder and urinary tubule infections such as cystitis and urethritis, and respiratory problems, including bronchitis. The resin is applied to wounds, where it protects and counters infection. A decoction of the bark is used to soothe eczema and psoriasis.

Caution Do not take larch if suffering from kidney disease.

Larrea tridentata (Zygophyllaceae) Chaparral, Creosote Bush

Description Thorny shrub growing to 6½ ft (2 m), with small finely divided leaves.

Habitat & Cultivation Chaparral is found in large numbers in the deserts of the southwestern U.S. and Mexico.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Chaparral contains about 12% resin and lignans, including nordihydroguaiauretic

acid. The latter is reportedly harmful to the lymph glands and kidneys, though recent research shows that it has beneficial antidiabetic properties. U.S. research published in 1996 demonstrated that other lignans have antiviral activity against HIV.

History & Folklore Widely used by Native Americans, chaparral was taken in the form of a decoction to treat stomach troubles and diarrhea. Young twigs were used for toothache. The leaves were applied as a poultice for respiratory problems and as a wash for skin problems.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Until the 1960s, chaparral remained in wide use in the U.S., with an average of 10 tons (9.07 tonnes) consumed each year. It was thought to be a beneficial remedy for rheumatic disease, venereal infections, urinary infections, and certain types of cancer, especially leukemia. Chaparral was also taken internally for skin afflictions such as acne and eczema, and applied as a lotion to sores, wounds, and rashes. In the early 1990s, sales of chaparral were banned in the U.S. and Britain due to concern over its potential toxic effect on the liver. It now seems likely that this is another herb that can, in rare cases, cause liver damage, as with some conventional medicines. In view of the uncertainty about its safety, any potential benefit from taking the herb must be weighed against the risks.

Related Species The North American *L. divaricata*, a close relative of chaparral, contains lignans, which have been shown to inhibit lymphoid tumor growth with no apparent harmful effect on normal lymphatic tissue.

⚠ Cautions Only take chaparral on professional advice. People with a history of liver disease should never take chaparral.

Laurus nobilis (Lauraceae) Bay Laurel

Description Aromatic evergreen shrub or tree growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has leathery, dark green leaves, small yellow male and female flowers, and shiny black berries.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Mediterranean countries, bay laurel prefers damp and shady sites. It is also a popular garden herb, cultivated largely for culinary use. The leaves are picked year round.

Parts Used Leaves, essential oil.

Constituents Bay laurel contains up to 3% volatile oil (including 30–50% cineole, linalool, alpha-pinene, alpha-terpineol acetate, mucilage, tannin, and resin).

History & Folklore In ancient Greece, bay laurel was used in divination by the Delphic Oracle. From ancient Rome comes the tradition that the sudden withering of a bay laurel tree bodes disaster